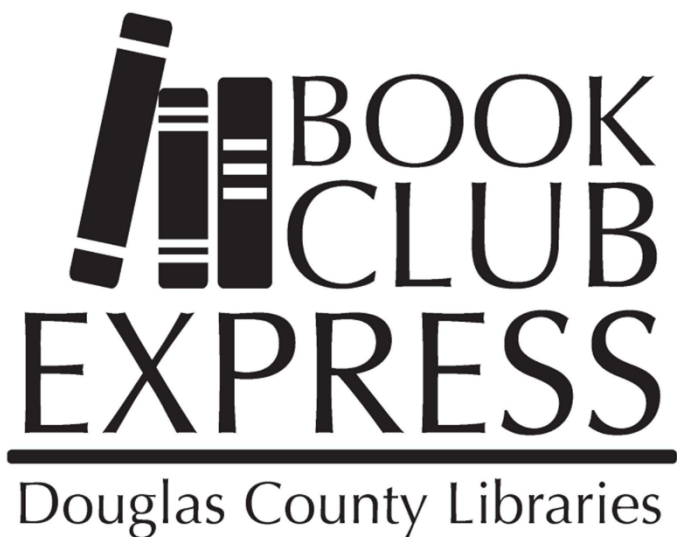




Atmosphere: A Love Story by Taylor Jenkins Reid

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Discussion Questions

1. Joan dreams of becoming an astronaut in a time when very few women are given the opportunity. What internal strengths does she draw upon during the processes of applying, training and then practicing for this career? Have you ever been in a situation where you were underestimated, or not given equal opportunities? What strengths did you draw upon?
2. Describe Joan's relationship with her sister, Barbara. What bonds them? What are their fundamental differences?
3. How would you characterize Joan's relationship with her niece, Frances? What does Joan provide for Frances that Barbara doesn't? How does this triangle of relationships change over time?
4. "She didn't want to lower herself to the game men played," Joan thinks. "To be like them. Why would she follow people who were lost?" How do Joan, Vanessa, Lydia and Donna all react differently to being women in a male-dominated field?
5. When Joan does finally make it to space, it's not what she expected. How does she process the realization that her life's dream has changed? Have you ever achieved a dream, only to discover you want something different now?
6. "People say opposites attract, but Joan found this to almost never be true. People just couldn't see the ways they were drawn to exactly who they feared --- or hoped --- they might be." Do you agree or disagree? Discuss.
7. Which of the other mission crew members were you most drawn to? Whose arc did you find most moving? Most surprising?
8. If you were making a movie or TV show of *ATMOSPHERE*, who would you cast in the lead roles?
9. What did you think of the book's ending? Why do you think the author chose to end the book that way, especially with that final line? What do you imagine for the characters in 10 years?
10. If you've read other books by Taylor Jenkins Reid, what themes does *ATMOSPHERE* share with her previous novels? What sets it apart?

Author Interview

DEBBIE ELLIOTT: The new novel "Atmosphere" starts in 1984 at the Johnson Space Center in Houston. Joan Goodwin is an astronaut, but her job this day is with mission control. She's tasked with being the only person who speaks directly to the crew aboard the space shuttle Navigator. Joan is a calm person, which is good, given the crisis that quickly unfolds.

TAYLOR JENKINS REID: (Reading) *Everyone is up out of their seats. Joan can barely hear herself think. She has been through simulations like this, with the pressure dropping rapidly and no way to stabilize it. They have ended only when the leak is found or the crew dies. This is NASA. We have a plan for this.*

DE: We have a plan for this. I love that line.

TJR: Thank you. I think I stole it from NASA (laughter), so all compliments go to NASA on that one.

DE: That's author Taylor Jenkins Reid. She didn't just write a gripping story about a space accident. "Atmosphere" covers the early days of the shuttle program and the challenges faced by the first women astronauts. That includes proving themselves. It also includes self-discovery. High-achieving astronomer Joan Goodwin never thought she'd ever fall in love. When she does, with fellow astronaut Vanessa Ford, the two have to keep their relationship quiet. The stakes get especially high during the crisis, 250 miles above the Earth, when Vanessa is the only astronaut aboard the Navigator who can communicate with mission control.

TJR: They are deploying a satellite when something goes wrong. There are two explosive cords that detonate. And one of them detonates incorrectly and sends shrapnel into the airlock, and also somewhere into the cabin. The cabin pressure begins to drop rapidly, which can be very fatal very quickly.

DE: Introduce us to Joan Goodwin. Who is she? And what is her life like before she joins NASA?

TJR: Yeah. So Joan Goodwin is an astronomer. She's been in love with the stars since she was a child. And when she hears that women are being accepted into the Astronaut Corps, she becomes very eager to apply. She actually applies twice before she gets in. And it's only once she gets to the Astronaut Corps and she is surrounded by this new group of people that she starts to realize she may not understand herself as much as she thought she did.

DE: At one point, Joan says to one of her new colleagues, I've always felt, when I look at the stars, I'm reminded that I'm never alone. What does she find at NASA?

TJR: She finds like-minded people. She finds people who understand her in a way that no one else really has before. They're all attempting to do something really exceptional. They're all attempting to leave the atmosphere. And the pull to do that is something that has been in her for a long time, but has always been hard to describe. And so when she meets a group of people who also feel that pull, she feels a kinship that she's never felt before, and she feels that

most specifically with Vanessa Ford. Vanessa seems to be able to articulate why she wants to go up there in a way that really captivates Joan.

DE: So the novel takes place - this is the early 1980s. It's toggling back and forth between the space disaster - right? - and the years leading up to it. As Joan and Vanessa and others are training, they are the second-ever astronaut cohort with women in it. What was NASA like for them back then?

TJR: You know, I read a lot of books about the space shuttle program. And one of the things that I kept seeing was how NASA, but also the press, had a lot of adjusting to do in allowing women into the Astronaut Corps. It's not just that a lot of the men had to learn how to work with women. It was also things as simple as the spacesuits were made for a male body. The parachutes during water survival training, the harnesses - all of them were made for a male body.

So there were a lot of things that the first few rounds of women entering the Astronaut Corps had to sort of raise their hand and say, hey, here's where we need things to change. And I'm always curious about that moment for anyone. But for women in general, how do they handle that moment? How do they make the world change in these small incremental ways? It was part of the appeal of writing about NASA for me. I got really curious what it was like to be one of those women in Group 8 or Group 9.

DE: Now, how did you research all of this? Did you actually go talk to people at NASA in those early days?

TJR: You know, the first thing I did was I went to the Johnson Space Center. We actually went into a decommissioned space shuttle, which was really incredible. I watched all the great space movies. I watched "Gravity" and "Apollo 13" and "The Right Stuff" and all that. But the fact is, the hardest part of this book was getting the mechanics of the space shuttle right and understanding the specifics of mission control. And for that, I needed help. And I'm very fortunate to be able to say that Paul Dye, who is the longest-serving flight director at NASA, who served during the space shuttle program and has since retired - he was very generous with his time and really helped to make this book what it is.

DE: That explains how you knew exactly how many latches there were on every hatch, and...

TJR: (Laughter) Yeah. And also, I will say, one of the things that I was surprised to find is that because NASA is a government organization, there is a lot of old PDFs you can find on the internet. So I have papers about the payload bay doors that were written in the 1970s. And, you know, when a sentence just got too convoluted for me to understand without an engineering degree, I called Paul Dye.

DE: Joan is a scientist, but she's also, at times, sharing her sense of faith. I'm wondering if we can get you to read some of that section of the book. It's this moment where she and Vanessa are talking about religious belief. And Joan says, the pursuit of a unifying theory to explain the universe is science, but it's also the pursuit of God.

TJR: This is Joan speaking to Vanessa.

(Reading) I would go so far as to say that as human beings, we are less of a who and more of a when. We are a moment in time when all of our cells have come together in this body. But our atoms were many things before, and they will be many things after. The air I'm breathing is the same air your ancestors breathed. Even what is in my body right now - the cells, the air, the bacteria - it's not only mine. It's a point of connection with every other living thing, made up of the same kind of particles, ruled by the same physical laws.

DE: Where does this come from? Is this your belief, as well?

TJR: I'm writing as Joan, but I would be lying if I didn't admit that a lot of Joan has rubbed off on me. When I decided to write about space, I didn't know that I would feel like that necessitated writing about spirituality, but the two feel very linked, to me. And I felt like Joan would be prompted in her life to have thought about these things, and I believed she would think of them this way. I'm not putting forth any new ideas, but this is who I believe Joan is. And it's one of my favorite things about her, and it is certainly something I've taken with me myself.

DE: Taylor Jenkins Reid. Her new novel is "Atmosphere." Thank you so much for being on the program.

TJR: Oh, thank you so much for having me.

Author Biography

Taylor Jenkins Reid is the author of the New York Times Bestselling novels *Atmosphere*, *Carrie Soto Is Back*, *Malibu Rising*, *Daisy Jones and The Six* and *The Seven Husbands of Evelyn Hugo*, as well as *One True Loves*, *Maybe in Another Life*, *After I Do*, and *Forever, Interrupted*. Her books have been chosen by Reese's Book Club, Read with Jenna, GMA Book Club, Indie Next, Best of Amazon, and Book of the Month. Her novel, *Daisy Jones and The Six*, is now a limited series on Amazon Prime. She lives in Los Angeles.

Reviews

"Would you go into space?".

That was the question I asked my husband as I sat in the passenger seat reading the latest novel by Taylor Jenkins Reid.

We both decided that, ultimately, we absolutely would not go into space and the opening pages of *Atmosphere*, firmly cemented that sentiment. Ha!

Unless you've been living under a rock, then you'll have noticed that the latest book by TJR is getting a lot of love. I'm going to add to that love because it's brilliant.

Admittedly, I wasn't overly drawn to the topic of space travel, but TJR has a knack for taking a seemingly random topic and making it completely absorbing. I wasn't that fussed for tennis when I read *Carrie Soto is Back* but was obsessed by the end of it and she's achieved the same with *Atmosphere*. I couldn't get enough of space travel.

However, *Atmosphere* is much more than a science fiction tale...

From the back.....

In the summer of 1980, astrophysics professor Joan Goodwin begins training to be an astronaut at Houston's Johnson Space Center, alongside an exceptional group of fellow candidates: Top Gun pilots Hank Redmond and John Griffin; mission specialist Lydia Danes; warm-hearted Donna Fitzgerald; and Vanessa Ford, the magnetic and mysterious aeronautical engineer.

As the new astronauts prepare for their first flights, Joan finds a passion and a love she never imagined and begins to question everything she believes about her place in the observable universe.

Then, in December of 1984, on mission STS-LR9, everything changes in an instant.

TJR has written a book that's part science fiction, a love story (that's a given it says that on the cover after all), its part historical fiction, part social commentary, part thriller and a tale of female empowerment. And it is completely engrossing, I couldn't get enough of Joan!

TJR had me hooked from the get-go. As I read the opening chapter, I could feel myself tensing up. I was literally on the edge of my seat waiting for disaster, I felt really claustrophobic. It's a long time since has book has managed to induce that level of anxiety in me.

That feeling increased tenfold as I worked my way through the final pages, I could barely breathe, I loved the tension between what was happening up there with the stars, mixed with those on the ground.

The backdrop to that though is Joan's secret relationship with a female colleague, something that was still taboo in the early eighties. As a female scientist, Joan has already faced a battle to be able to achieve her dreams and ambitions.

I loved that juxtaposition. On the one hand we're seeing amazing progress with the development of the space shuttle programme; it's exciting, humanity is taking these great leaps forward. At the same time, Joan is still facing prejudice, sexism and homophobia.

Joan and her colleagues – Lydia, Donna and Vanessa – are brilliant. They're as equally talented as their male counterparts but have to work twice as hard to justify their place on the space program. There are instances where they do face sexism from certain members of the astronaut corps. They know when the first woman makes the trip into space, there can be no room for error, their future careers are dependent on it being a success.

Joan faces the added pressure of hiding the fact she's in a relationship with a woman. Joan comes across as a little naïve when it comes to love and relationships. She's never really given much thought to her sexuality before. She's almost taken by complete surprise when she comes to the realisation that she's a lesbian. She's a wonderful character who won't be held back. She loves deeply and cares for those around her (I especially loved how she took care of her niece). She's passionate about the stars and the universe, I loved her view of the world, it became infectious the more I read.

I loved seeing how Joan became more accepting of herself and seeing the love and intimacy develop between her and her partner. It was beautiful and hard to see why anyone would find it reprehensible.

It'd be easy to sit here and say "well, it was the eighties", but there are people who still hold those same views today, which is a pretty depressing state of affairs.

Atmosphere doesn't overwhelm readers with technical jargon. There's a balance between Joan's training and her day-to-day life, a life she'd never dreamed she'd have. TJR is a fabulous storyteller, she manages to take a huge, expansive topic – like space – and ground it in human experience.

I can see Atmosphere making a brilliant film, I could picture it as I kept on reading. I'd certainly be buying a cinema ticket and maybe watching from behind my hands!

Everything you've heard about Atmosphere is true, read it and then take the time to look up at the stars!

"Space belonged to no one, but Earth belonged to all of them." Taylor Jenkins Reid

Read-Alikes

Shoot the Moon by Isa Arsen

Intelligent but isolated recent physics graduate Annie Fisk feels an undeniable pull toward space. Her childhood memories dimmed by loss, she has left behind her home, her family, and her first love in pursuit of intellectual fulfillment. When she finally lands a job as a NASA secretary during the Apollo 11 mission, the work is everything she dreamed, and while she feels a budding attraction to one of the engineers, she can't get distracted. Not now. When her inability to ignore mistaken calculations propels her into a new position, Annie finds herself torn between her ambition, her heart, and a mysterious discovery that upends everything she knows to be scientifically true. Can she overcome her doubts and reach beyond the limits of time and space? Affecting, immersive, and kaleidoscopic, *Shoot the Moon* tells the story of one singular life at multiple points in time, one woman's quest to honor both her head and her heart amid the human toll of scientific progress.

The Three Lives by Cate Kay by Kate Fagan

Cate Kay knows how to craft a story. As the creator of a bestselling book trilogy that struck box office gold as a film series, she's one of the most successful authors of her generation. The thing is, Cate Kay doesn't really exist. She's never attended author events or granted any interviews. Her real identity had been a closely guarded secret, until now. As a young adult, she and her best friend Amanda dreamed of escaping their difficult homes and moving to California to become movie stars. But the day before their grand adventure, a tragedy shattered their dreams and Cate has been on the run ever since, taking on different names and charting a new future. But after a shocking revelation, Cate understands that returning home is the only way she'll be a whole person again.